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Apple Card: 12 Fintech Companies Driving Credit Card Innovation

Market Research ⌚ 4 min read

Jaclyn Robinson, Senior Manager of Content Marketing at Crunchbase

Apple announced that it's launching a credit card this summer called Apple Card.

In partnership with Goldman Sachs and MasterCard, the technology company is looking to disrupt a category that hasn't seen breakthrough innovation in

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well played Apple, well played.

I know what you're thinking, "What if a restaurant or store doesn't accept Apple Pay?"

Don't worry, Apple's rolling out a sleek card for that exact scenario. On the front, your name and the iconic Apple logo laser-etched in titanium alloy with EMV microchip for added security.

When the dust settled from Apple's announcement, I looked at Crunchbase's dataset to see which companies have raised capital – from 2018 to present – to drive innovation in the credit card space.

Here's what I uncovered (in no particular order).

Fintech companies driving credit card innovation

Plastiq

Latest round: Series C

Amount: \$27M

Announced date: Nov 19, 2018

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Brex

Latest round: Series C

Amount: \$125M

Announced date: Oct 5, 2018

San Francisco-based Brex, a fintech unicorn [\$1B+ valuation], launched a corporate credit card for technology companies that enable them to access 20x higher limits, completely automate expense management, eliminate receipt tracking, and integrate with any accounting system.

Deserve

Latest round: Series C

Amount: \$19M

Announced date: Aug 27, 2018

Through machine learning technology and alternative data, Deserve helps millennials and Gen Z gain access to fair credit products. Their mission is to help the next generation of credit owners gain financial independence.

Spendesk

Latest round: Series A

Amount: £8M [\$10.5M US]

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Customers get access to single-use virtual cards with a unique card number for each payment for safer online purchasing.

Petal

Latest round: Series B

Amount: \$30M

Announced date: Jan 29, 2019

Have you ever looked at your credit card statement and scratched your head in confusion? What about reading credit card information on a bank's website? All the financial jargon that comes with credit cards is off-putting and makes it harder for consumers to make informed decisions. Petal wants to solve this issue by making credit honest, simple, and accessible.

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Tally Technologies

Recent round: Series B

Amount: \$45M

Announced date: Jul 24, 2018

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Zero

Latest round: Venture

Amount: \$16M

Announced date: Nov 17, 2018

Zero is the first banking experience to combine the simplicity of a debit card with the cash back (and other rewards) of a credit card. Customers get access to a checking account, a credit card with great rewards, and an app that brings it all together seamlessly.

Nubank

Latest round: Series B, secondary market round

Amount: \$180M

Announced date: Oct 8, 2018

Nubank, based in São Paulo, Brazil, is on a mission to end the complexity surrounding finance in a country that has soaring interest rates. To make this a reality, Nubank issues a free credit card (no annual fee, no maintenance cost, free and unlimited bank transfers) that holders can use. Whenever a cardholder uses a Nubank credit card, the company gets a portion of the transaction from the establishment where the purchase was made.

Extend

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Extend is a platform that enables business cardholders to share their credit card with employees and freelancers without ever exposing their card number or losing control over spend.

JaJa

Latest round: Equity crowdfunding

Amount: £5M [\$6.6M US]

Announced date: Jan 16, 2019

While currently in beta, JaJa partnered with Visa to create a mobile-first credit card with no fees, instant issuing, credit sharing, and more.

CreditStacks

Latest round: Seed

Amount: \$4M

Announced date: Jan 25, 2018

CreditStacks is partnering with Mastercard [the same company Apple is using for their credit card] and First Covenant Bank to issue premium credit cards to customers who are new to credit.

Olly Smart Credit Card

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Olly is a digital credit card built for India's working masses and young people. Customers can use this card for day-to-day expenses and make re-payments via Olly's app ensuring late fees are avoided. This ultimately helps build a good credit score in a shorter period of time.

Final thoughts

When a company has deep pockets, as Apple does [\$245 billion cash on hand], and they enter a new market or category...everyone takes notice.

While having a billion dollar company enter your space can be nerve-racking, the good news is that the pace of innovation inevitably picks up. Not only is this great for consumers, but it's also great for competition as companies of all sizes push themselves to challenge the status quo.

For a space that hasn't seen very much breakthrough innovation over the years, Apple entering the space is just what the financial advisor ordered.

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